Growth and decline

For most of human history, the world’s population had grown only slowly. It began to increase more rapidly in Western Europe and the USA in the early years of the Industrial Revolution, when British economist Thomas Malthus warned of a future famine. His fears proved premature, however, because food production increased more quickly than many expected. Life expectancy also fell in the new industrial cities, due to infectious diseases. It rose again with better healthcare and nutrition, cleaner water, and more rights for workers. By 1924, there were 2 billion people in the world, by 1960 there were 3 billion, and by 2022 there were 8 billion.